have played would have been DEFECT too. Admittedly I'd have suffered the penalty for mutual defection, but if I'd cooperated I'd have got the sucker's pay-off which is even worse. Now let's turn to the other thing you could have done (look at the left-hand column), play the COOPERATE card. Once again DEFECT is the best thing I could have done. If I had cooperated we'd both have got the rather high score of $300. But if I'd defected I'd have got even more—$500. The conclusion is that, regardless of which card you play, my best move is *Always Defect*.

So I have worked out by impeccable logic that, regardless of what you do, I must defect. And you, with no less impeccable logic, will work out just the same thing. So when two rational players meet, they will both defect, and both will end up with a fine or a low pay-off. Yet each knows perfectly well that, if only they had *both* played COOPERATE, both would have obtained the relatively high reward for mutual cooperation ($300 in our example). That is why the game is called a dilemma, why it seems so maddeningly paradoxical, and why it has even been proposed that there ought to be a law against it.

'Prisoner' comes from one particular imaginary example. The currency in this case is not money but prison sentences. Two men—call them Peterson and Moriarty—are in jail, suspected of collaborating in a crime. Each prisoner, in his separate cell, is invited to betray his colleague (DEFECT) by turning King's evidence against him. What happens depends upon what both prisoners do, and neither knows what the other has done. If Peterson throws the blame entirely on Moriarty, and Moriarty renders the story plausible by remaining silent (cooperating with his erstwhile and, as it turns out, treacherous friend), Moriarty gets a heavy jail sentence while Peterson gets off scot-free, having yielded to the temptation to defect. If each betrays the other, both are convicted of the crime, but receive some credit for giving evidence and get a somewhat reduced, though still stiff, sentence, the punishment for mutual defection. If both cooperate (with each other, not with the authorities) by refusing to speak, there is not enough evidence to convict either of them of the main crime, and they receive a small sentence for a lesser offence, the reward for mutual cooperation. Although it may seem odd to call a jail sentence a 'reward', that is how the men would see it if the alternative was a longer spell behind bars. You will notice that, although the 'pay-offs' are not in dollars but in jail sentences, the essential features of the game are preserved (look at the rank order of desirability